

DC Thomson: one front door for every subscriber

A Dundee publisher with more than a century of history and a transformation agenda: more digital subscriptions, and investment in technology, data and AI. Its subscribers still have to pick between separate phone lines depending on which title they read and what went wrong.

£41M

subscription revenue, FY to Mar 2025 (+1%)

50,000+

paying subscribers to regional news titles

4

separate subscriber phone lines, by title and topic

£31M

pre-tax profit; still investing in tech, data and AI

Why now

- **Transformation has an owner.** Ella Dolphin became Deputy CEO in May 2025 with a remit for M&A and transformation across the portfolio.
- **Subscriptions are the growth engine, and behind plan.** Regional titles passed 50,000 subscribers, short of the 75,000-by-2025 target. Retention matters as much as acquisition.
- **Open to partner tech.** In May 2026 they added AI narration (BeyondWords x Puggig) to the Stylist and Press and Journal apps. They buy focused tools; they don't build everything themselves.
- **Service is a team they're investing in.** They have a Customer Experience team in Dundee (Meadowside) and have advertised Customer Support Advisor roles.

What subscribers deal with today

- **Four numbers:** Courier digital (0800 029 4956), Press and Journal digital (0800 029 4955), home delivery (01382 575427) and the DC Thomson Shop for magazines (0800 904 7260).
- **Different hours per line:** news digital Mon–Fri 8–18 and Sat 9–17; magazine shop Mon–Fri 9–17 only.
- **Repeat reasons:** Trustpilot rates the Shop 4.8/5, but the complaints cluster on late or missing issues, billing frequency, refunds and early renewal reminders.
- **Self-service is already there:** a help centre and Air Business subscription management (renewed on a 3-year contract). The tools exist, but customers aren't steered to them.

The pitch in one line: DC Thomson doesn't need another chatbot or contact-centre platform. It needs one front door that steers each subscriber to the fastest fix, so its team can spend more time on the conversations that keep subscribers.

From “find the right number” to “we'll show you the way”

Today: the subscriber does the routing

Subscriber
with a problem, at 21:40 on a Sunday

Courier digital
0800 029 4956
Mon–Sat, office hours

P&J digital
0800 029 4955
Mon–Sat, office hours

Home delivery
01382 575427

Magazine shop
0800 904 7260
Mon–Fri 9–17

Help centre
articles + e-mail

My Account
Air Business portal

Six routes, and every one requires the subscriber to already know which one fits. When in doubt, people phone.

With reChanneld: one front door

“Hi! What can we help with?”
the same on every title's help page, app and e-mail footer

↓ routes by topic, title, time and queue ↓

Self-service
missing issue, pause, billing date

Help article
log-in, app, e-edition

Form
refunds, complaints

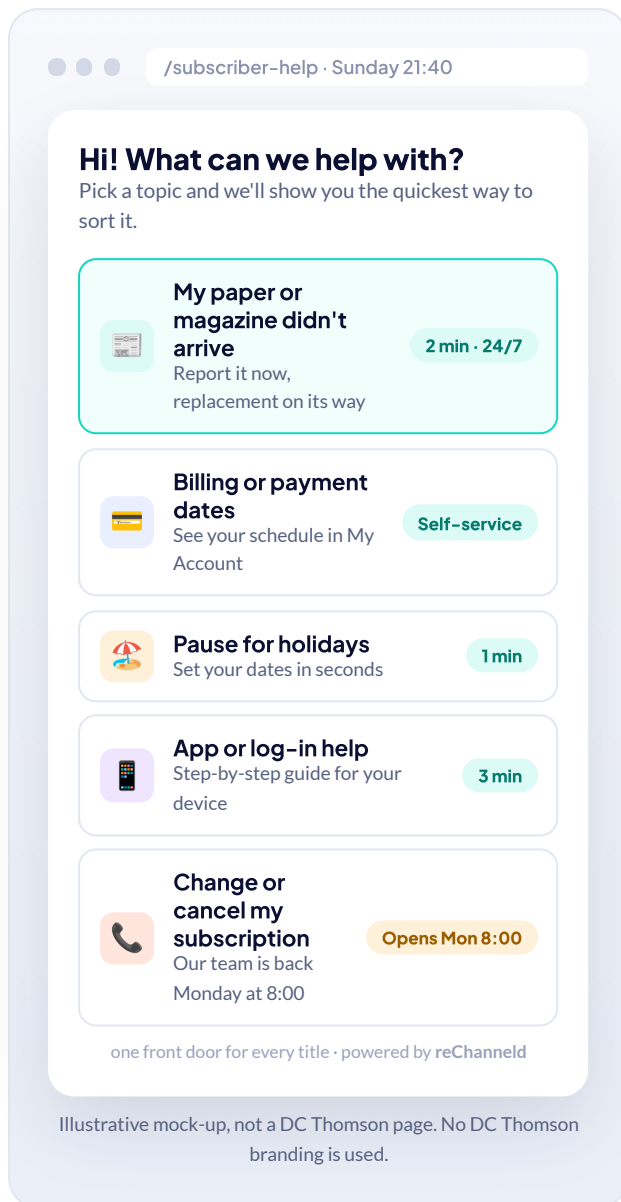
The right team
cancel, change, vulnerable readers

Every channel stays open. The fastest route is simply shown first, with honest wait times. It works alongside Air Business and the existing help centre.

Contact reasons → best channel (proposed starting rules)

TOPIC	ROUTE FIRST TO	WHY
Paper or magazine didn't arrive	Self-service	A recurring complaint. A form plus an automatic replacement or credit takes 2 minutes, 24/7, and no call is needed.
Billing date or payment frequency	My Account	Shows the schedule in the Air Business portal. That prevents the “monthly vs quarterly” surprise behind several complaints.
Holiday pause / change address	Self-service	Simple, high-volume and seasonal. Ideal for peaks before the summer and Christmas holidays.
Can't log in / app / e-edition	Help article	A step-by-step guide by device, with chat as the fallback.
Refund or complaint	Form → team	A structured form arrives with all the details, so the agent resolves it in one touch.
Cancel or downgrade	Phone, priority	This is where a human conversation saves revenue. Give these callers the shortest queue.

The topics come from public reviews and contact pages. In a pilot, DC Thomson's own contact data decides the final rules.



Where the value comes from

- **Fewer avoidable calls.** Missing issues, billing dates and pauses move to self-service, around the clock.
- **Shorter queues for the calls that matter.** Cancellation and win-back callers reach an agent faster, which protects the £41 M subscription line.
- **Help outside office hours.** Subscribers on evenings and Sundays get an answer instead of a closed line.
- **One set of rules for every title.** News, magazines and Beano can share a single console, configured per brand.
- **Visibility.** Live data on which topics reach which channel, by title. That gives the transformation programme a measurable KPI.

Proof from the Nordics

S-Bank (3.3 M customers, ~1 M interactions a year) uses reChanneld next to its Aulis chatbot to guide customers to the right channel 24/7. reChanneld clients typically guide **79%** of contacts to their preferred channel.

What it doesn't require

No new chatbot, no CRM change and no replacement of Air Business. reChanneld sits on top of the help pages that already exist and is configured by the CX team.

Suggested pilot

WEEKS 1–2

Map

Pull 3 months of contact reasons from one title, e.g. The Courier, and agree the routing rules.

WEEKS 3–8

Nudge

reChanneld goes live on The Courier's help pages, with A/B tests on the top 5 topics.

WEEK 9

Decide

Compare call volume, self-service share and evening/weekend use against the baseline, then roll out to other titles.

Who to contact

Ella Dolphin

Deputy CEO

Owns transformation across the portfolio. The executive sponsor. Approach second, with a result or a referral.

Customer Experience lead

Dundee CX team · [find on LinkedIn](#)

Feels the call volume every day. The main contact: approach first.

Subscriptions / consumer revenue lead

[Find on LinkedIn](#)

Owns retention and the 50k-to-75k gap. Approach in parallel with the CX lead.

1 · LinkedIn note (CX lead)

Day 1 · 173 characters

Hi [Name], DC Thomson subscribers can choose between 4 phone lines. We help publishers guide readers to the fastest fix instead. Made a short idea for you, could I share it?

3 · Follow-up

Day 7 · same thread

Hi [Name], one detail: magazine subscribers can only reach you on weekdays 9–5, so a missing issue noticed on a Saturday waits until Monday. A 24/7 front door fixes that on day one. One-pager attached in case it's useful.

Touko

4 · Exec note (Ella Dolphin)

Day 10 · LinkedIn or e-mail

Hi Ella, a quick idea for DC Thomson's subscriber experience: one front door across all titles that steers missing-issue and billing questions to self-service 24/7, so your team has more time for retention calls. One-page proposal attached. Would a 20-minute look be useful?

Touko

2 · E-mail (CX lead + subscriptions lead)

Day 2 · Subject: One front door for DC Thomson subscribers

Hi [Name],

Your subscribers can reach you on four different numbers, depending on the title and the problem, with different opening hours on each. And what they call about repeats: missing issues, billing dates, renewals.

reChanneld puts one “How can we help?” front door on your help pages. It sends simple requests to self-service around the clock and keeps your team's time for cancellations and win-backs, where a conversation protects revenue. It works with Air Business and your existing help centre, so there's no new platform to build.

Nordic companies such as S-Bank (3.3 M customers) use it today, and our clients typically guide 79% of contacts to their preferred channel.

I've put together a short proposal for DC Thomson, including a suggested 8-week pilot on The Courier. Would 20 minutes next week work to go through it?

Best,
Touko Laakkonen
reChanneld

Send rules: Tue–Thu, 8:30–9:30 UK time. Attach only page 3 (the mock-up and value) to the e-mail, and keep the full brief for the meeting. Stop the sequence as soon as anyone replies.